

'But come, my lord cardinal, you who are so profound a genius, try if you cannot find a means to assist this poor king, without compromising ourselves.'

'And that is exactly what I am not willing to do, my dear sire,' said Mazarin. 'If England were to act exactly according to my wishes, she could not act better than she does; if I directed the policy of England from this place, I should not direct it otherwise. Governed as she is governed, England is an eternal nest of contention for all Europe. Holland protects Charles II, let Holland do so; they will quarrel, they will fight. Let them destroy each other's navies, we can construct ours with the wrecks of their vessels; when we shall save our money to buy nails.'

'Oh, how paltry and mean is all this that you are telling me, monsieur le cardinal!'

'Yes, but nevertheless it is true, sire; you must confess that. Still further. Suppose I admit, for a moment, the possibility of breaking your word, and evading the treaty—such a thing as sometimes happens, but that is when some great interest is to be promoted by it, or when the treaty is found to be too troublesome—well, you will authorize the engagement asked of you: France—her banner, which is the same thing—will cross the Straits and will fight; France will be conquered.'

'Why so?'

'Ma foi! we have a pretty general to fight under—this Charles II.! Worcester gave us proofs of that.'

'But he will no longer have to deal with Cromwell, monsieur.'

'But he will have to deal with Monk, who is quite as dangerous. The brave brewer of whom we are speaking, was a visionary; he had moments of exaltation, of inflation, during which he ran over like an over-filled cask; and from the chinks there always escaped some drops of his thoughts, and by the sample the whole of his thought was to be made out. Cromwell has thus allowed us more than ten times to penetrate into his very soul, when one would have conceived that soul to be enveloped in triple brass, as Horace had it. But Monk! Oh, sire, God defend you from ever having anything to transact politically with Monk. It is he who has given me, in one year, all the gray hairs I have. Monk is no fanatic; unfortunately he is a politician; he does not overflow, he keeps close together. For ten years he has had his eyes fixed upon one object, and nobody has yet been able to ascertain what. Every morning, as Louis xi

advised, he burns his nightcap. Therefore, on the day when this plan, slowly and solitarily ripened, shall break forth, it will break forth with all the conditions of success which always accompany an unforeseen event. That is Monk, sire, of whom, perhaps, you have never even heard—of whom, perhaps, you did not even know the name, before your brother, Charles II, who knows what he is, pronounced it before you. He is a marvel of depth and tenacity, the two only things against which intelligence and ardour are blunted. Sire, I had ardour when I was young; I always was intelligent. I may safely boast of it, because I am reproached with it. I have done very well with these two qualities, since, from the son of a fisherman of Piscina, I have become prime minister to the king of France; and in that position your majesty will perhaps acknowledge I have rendered some service to the throne of your majesty. Well, sire, if I had met with Monk on my way, instead of Monsieur de Beaufort, Monsieur de Retz, or Monsieur le Prince—well, we should have been ruined. If you engage yourself rashly, sire, you will fall into the talons of this politic soldier. The casque of Monk, sire, is an iron coffer, and no one has the key of it. Therefore, near him, or rather before him, I bow, sire, for I have nothing but a velvet cap.'

'What do you think Monk wishes to do, then?'

'Eh! sire, if I knew that, I would not tell you to mistrust him, for I should be stronger than he; but with him, I am afraid to guess—to guess!—you understand my word?—for if I thought I had guessed, I should stop at an idea, and, in spite of myself, should pursue that idea. Since that man has been in power yonder, I am like one of the damned in Dante whose neck Satan has twisted, and who walk forward looking around behind them. I am travelling towards Madrid, but I never lose sight of London. To guess, with that devil of a man, is to deceive one's self and to deceive one's self is to ruin one's self. God keep me from ever seeking to guess what he aims at; I confine myself to watching what he does, and that is well enough. Now I believe—you observe the meaning of the word I believe?—I believe, with respect to Monk, ties one to nothing—I believe that he has a strong inclination to succeed Cromwell. Your Charles II has already caused proposals to be made to him by ten persons; he has satisfied himself with driving these ten meddlers from his presence, without saying anything to them but, "Begone, or I will have you hung." That man is a sepulchre! At this moment Monk is affecting devotion to the

Rump Parliament; of this devotion, I am not the dupe. Monk has no wish to be assassinated,—an assassination would stop him in the middle of his operations; and his work must be accomplished;—so I believe—but do not believe what I believe, sire: for as I say I believe from habit—I believe that Monk is keeping on friendly terms with the parliament till the day comes for dispersing it. You are asked for swords, but they are to fight against Monk. God preserve you from fighting against Monk, sire; for Monk would beat us, and I should never console myself after being beaten by Monk. I should say to myself, Monk has foreseen that victory ten years. For God's sake, sire, out of friendship for you, if not out of consideration for himself, let Charles II keep quiet. Your majesty will give him a little income here; give him one of your châteaux. Yes, yes—wait awhile. But I forget the treaty—that famous treaty of which we were just now speaking. Your majesty has not even the right to give him a château.'

'How is that?'

'Yes, yes; your majesty is bound not to grant hospitality to King Charles, and to compel him to leave France even. It was on this account we forced him to quit you, and yet here he is again. Sire, I hope you will give your brother to understand that he cannot remain with us; that it is impossible he should be allowed to compromise us; or I myself—'

'Enough, my lord,' said Louis XIV, rising. 'In refusing me a million, perhaps you may be right; your millions are your own. In refusing me two hundred gentlemen, you are still further in the right; for you are prime minister, and you have, in the eyes of France, the responsibility of peace and war. But that you should pretend to prevent me, who am king, from extending my hospitality to the grandson of Henry IV, to my cousin-german, to the companion of my childhood—there your power stops, and there begins my will.'

'Sire,' said Mazarin, delighted at being let off so cheaply, and who had, besides, only fought so earnestly to arrive at that,—'sire, I shall always bend before the will of my king. Let my king, then, keep near him, or in one of his châteaux, the king of England; let Mazarin know it, but let not the minister know it.'

'Good-night, my lord,' said Louis XIV, 'I go away in despair.'
'But convinced, and that is all I desire, sire,' replied Mazarin.

'Yes, that is it exactly. Richard inherited after the death of his father, and England at the abdication of Richard. The treaty formed part of the inheritance, whether in the hands of M. Richard or in the hands of England. The treaty is, then, still as good, as valid as ever. Why should you evade it, sire? What is changed? Charles wants to-day what we were not willing to grant him ten years ago, but that was foreseen and provided against. You are the ally of England, sire, and not of Charles II. It was doubtless wrong, from a family point of view, to sign a treaty with a man who had cut off the head of the king your father's brother-in-law, and to contract an alliance with a parliament which they call yonder the Rump Parliament; it was unbecoming, I acknowledge, but it was not unskilful from a political point of view, since, thanks to that treaty, I saved your majesty, then a minor, the trouble and danger of a foreign war, which the Fronde—you remember the Fronde, sire?—the young king hung his head—'which the Fronde might have fatally complicated. And thus I prove to your majesty that to change our plan now, without warning our allies, would be at once unskilful and dishonest. We should make war with the aggression on our side; we should make it, deserving to have it made against us; and we should have the appearance of fearing it whilst provoking it, for a permission granted to five hundred men, to two hundred men, to fifty men, to ten men, is still a permission. One Frenchman, that is the nation; one uniform, that is the army. Suppose, sire, for example, that you should have war with Holland, which, sooner or later, will certainly happen; or with Spain, which will perhaps ensue if your marriage fails' (Mazarin stole a furtive glance at the king), 'and there are a thousand causes that might yet make your marriage fail,—well, would you approve of England's sending to the United Provinces or to Spain a regiment, a company, a squadron even, of English gentlemen? Would you think that they kept within the limits of their treaty of alliance?'

Louis listened; it seemed so strange to him that Mazarin should invoke good faith, and be the author of so many political tricks, called Mazarinades. 'And yet,' said the king, 'without manifest of my authorization, I cannot prevent gentlemen of my states from passing over into England, if such should be their good pleasure.'

'You should compel them to return, sire, or at least protest against their presence as enemies in a allied country.'

channel, and these friends only want a leader and a banner. When they see me, when they behold the banner of France, they will rally around me, for they will comprehend that I have your support. The colours of the French uniform will be worth as much to me as the million M. de Mazarin refuses us,"—for he was pretty well assured I should refuse him that million.—"I shall conquer with these five hundred gentlemen, sire, and all the honour will be yours." Now, that is what he said, or to that purpose, was it not?—turning those plain words into brilliant metaphors and pompous images, for they are fine talkers in that family! The father talked even on the scaffold."

The perspiration of shame stood on the brow of Louis. He felt that it was inconsistent with his dignity to hear his brother thus insulted, but he did not yet know how to act with him to whom every one yielded, even his mother. At last he made an effort.

'But,' said he, 'my lord cardinal, it is not five hundred men, it is only two hundred.'

'Well, but you see I guessed what he wanted.'

'I never denied that you had a penetrating eye, and that was why I thought you would not refuse my brother Charles a thing so simple and so easy to grant him as what I ask of you in his name, my lord cardinal, or rather in my own.'

'Sire,' said Mazarin, 'I have studied policy thirty years; first, under the auspices of M. le Cardinal Richelieu; and then alone. This policy has not always been over-honest, it must be allowed, but it has never been unskilful. Now that which is proposed to your majesty is dishonest and unskilful at the same time.'

'Dishonest, monsieur!'

'Sire, you entered into a treaty with Cromwell.'

'Yes, and in that very treaty Cromwell signed his name above mine.'

'Why did you sign yours so low down, sire? Cromwell found a good place, and he took it; that was his custom. I return, then, to M. Cromwell. You have a treaty with him, that is to say, with England, since when you signed that treaty M. Cromwell was England.'

'M. Cromwell is dead.'

'Do you think so, sire?'

'No doubt he is, since his son Richard has succeeded him, and has abdicated.'

The king made no answer, and retired quite pensive, convinced, not of all Mazarin had told him, but of one thing which he took care not to mention to him; and that was, that it was necessary for him to study seriously both his own affairs and those of Europe, for he found them very difficult and very obscure. Louis found the king of England seated in the same place where he had left him. On perceiving him, the English prince arose; but at the first glance he saw discouragement written in dark letters upon his cousin's brow. Then, speaking first, as if to facilitate the painful avowal that Louis had to make to him,—

'Whatever it may be,' said he, 'I shall never forget all the kindness, all the friendship you have exhibited towards me.'

'Alas!' replied Louis, in a melancholy tone, 'only barren good-will, my brother.'

Charles II became extremely pale; he passed his cold hand over his brow, and struggled for a few instants against a faintness that made him tremble. 'I understand,' said he at last, 'no more hope!'

Louis seized the hand of Charles II. 'Wait, my brother,' said he, 'precipitate nothing; everything may change; hasty resolutions ruin all causes; add another year of trial, I implore you, to the years you have already undergone. You have, to induce you to act now rather than at another time, neither occasion nor opportunity. Come with me, my brother; I will give you one of my residences, whichever you prefer, to inhabit. I, with you, will keep my eyes upon events; we will prepare. Come, then, my brother, have courage!'

Charles II withdrew his hand from that of the king, and drawing back, to salute him with more ceremony, 'With all my heart, thanks!' replied he, 'sire; but I have prayed without success to the greatest king on earth; now I will go and ask a miracle of God.' And he went out without being willing to hear any more, his head carried loftily, his hand trembling, with a painful contraction of his noble countenance, and that profound gloom which, finding no more hope in the world of men, appeared to go beyond it, and ask it in worlds unknown. The officer of musketeers, on seeing him pass by thus pale, bowed almost to his knees as he saluted him. He then took a flambeau, called two musketeers, and descended the deserted staircase with the unfortunate king, holding in his left hand his hat, the plume of which swept the steps. Arrived at

the door, the musketeer asked the king which way he was going, that he might direct the musketeers.

‘Monsieur,’ replied Charles II, in a subdued voice, ‘you who have known my father, say, did you ever pray for him? If you have done so, do not forget me in your prayers. Now, I am going alone, and beg of you not to accompany me, or have me accompanied any further.’

The officer bowed and sent away the musketeers into the interior of the palace. But he himself remained an instant under the porch watching the departing Charles II, till he was lost in the turn of the next street. ‘To him as to his father formerly,’ murmured he, ‘Athos, if he were here, would say with reason, — “Salute fallen majesty!”’ Then, reascending the staircase: ‘Oh! the vile service that I follow!’ said he at every step. ‘Oh! my pitiful master! Life thus carried on is no longer tolerable, and it is at length time that I should do something! No more generosity, no more energy! The master has succeeded, the pupil is starved forever. Mordieux! I will not resist. Come, you men,’ continued he, entering the ante-chamber, ‘why are you all looking at me so? Extinguish these torches and return to your posts. Ah! you were guarding me? Yes, you watch over me, do you not, worthy fellows? Brave fools! I am not the Duc de Guise. Begone! They will not assassinate me in the little passage. Besides,’ added he, in a low voice, ‘that would be a resolution, and no resolutions have been formed since Monsieur le Cardinal Richelieu died. Now, with all his faults, that was a man! It is settled: to-morrow I will throw my cassock to the nettles.’

Then, reflecting: ‘No,’ said he, ‘not yet! I have one great trial to make and I will make it; but that, and I swear it, shall be the last, Mordieux!’

He had not finished speaking when a voice issued from the king’s chamber.

‘Monsieur le lieutenant!’ said this voice.

‘Here I am,’ replied he.

‘The king desires to speak to you.’

‘Humph!’ said the lieutenant, ‘perhaps of what I was thinking about.’ And he went into the king’s apartment.

Chapter XI

Mazarin’s Policy



INSTEAD of the hesitation with which he had accosted the cardinal a quarter of an hour before, there might be read in the eyes of the young king that will against which a struggle might be maintained, and which might be crushed by its own impotence, but which, at least, would preserve, like a wound in the depth of the heart, the remembrance of its defeat.

‘This time, my lord cardinal, we have to deal with something more easily found than a million.’

‘Do you think so, sire?’ said Mazarin, looking at the king with that penetrating eye which was accustomed to read to the bottom of hearts.

‘Yes, I think so; and when you know the object of my request—’

‘And do you think I do not know it, sire?’

‘You know what remains for me to say to you?’

‘Listen, sire; these are King Charles’s own words—’

‘Oh, impossible!’

‘Listen. “And if that miserly, beggarly Italian,” said he—’

‘My lord cardinal!’

‘That is the sense, if not the words. Eh! Good heavens! I wish him no ill on that account; one is biased by his passions. He said to you: “If that vile Italian refuses the million we ask of him, sire,—if we are forced, for want of money, to renounce diplomacy, well, then, we will ask him to grant us five hundred gentlemen.”’

The king started, for the cardinal was only mistaken in the number.

‘Is not that it, sire?’ cried the minister, with a triumphant accent. ‘And then he added some fine words: he said, “I have friends on the other side of the

‘So it must be then!’ said he; ‘my brother the king of England will die of hunger.’

‘Sire,’ replied Mazarin, in the same tone, ‘remember this proverb, which I give you as the expression of the soundest policy: “Rejoice at being poor when your neighbour is poor likewise.”’

Louis meditated this for a few moments, with an inquisitive glance directed to the paper, one end of which remained under the bolster.

‘Then,’ said he, ‘it is impossible to comply with my demand for money, my lord cardinal, is it?’

‘Absolutely, sire.’

‘Remember, this will secure me a future enemy, if he succeed in recovering his crown without my assistance.’

‘If your majesty only fears that, you may be quite at ease,’ replied Mazarin, eagerly.

‘Very well, I say no more about it,’ exclaimed Louis XIV

‘Have I at least convinced you, sire?’ placing his hand upon that of the young king.

‘Perfectly.’

‘If there be anything else, ask it, sire; I shall most happy to grant it to you, having refused this.’

‘Anything else, my lord?’

‘Why yes; am I not devoted body and soul to your majesty? Hola! Bernouin!—lights and guards for his majesty! His majesty is returning to his own chamber.’

‘Not yet, monsieur: since you place your good-will at my disposal, I will take advantage of it.’

‘For yourself, sire?’ asked the cardinal, hoping that his niece was at length about to be named.

‘No, monsieur, not for myself,’ replied Louis, ‘but still for my brother Charles.’

The brow of Mazarin again became clouded, and he grumbled a few words that the king could not catch.

Chapter XII

The King and the Lieutenant



As soon as the king saw the officer enter, he dismissed his valet de chambre and his gentleman.

‘Who is on duty to-morrow, monsieur?’ asked he.

The lieutenant bowed his head with military politeness, and replied, ‘I am, sire.’

‘What! still you?’

‘Always I, sire.’

‘How can that be, monsieur?’

‘Sire, when travelling, the musketeers supply all the posts of your majesty’s household; that is to say, yours, her majesty the queen’s, and monsieur le cardinal’s, the latter of whom borrows of the king the best part, or rather the numerous part, of the royal guard.’

‘But in the interims?’

‘There are no interims, sire, but for twenty or thirty men who rest out of a hundred and twenty. At the Louvre it is very different, and if I were at the Louvre I should rely upon my brigadier; but, when travelling, sire, no one knows what may happen, and I prefer doing my duty myself.’

‘Then you are on guard every day?’

‘And every night. Yes, sire.’

‘Monsieur, I cannot allow that—I will have you rest.’

‘That is very kind, sire; but I will not.’

‘What do you say?’ said the king, who did not at first comprehend the full meaning of this reply.

‘I say, sire, that I will not expose myself to the chance of a fault. If the devil had a trick to play on me, you understand, sire, as he knows the man with

whom he has to deal, he would chose the moment when I should not be there. My duty and the peace of my conscience before everything, sire.'

'But such duty will kill you, monsieur.'

'Eh! sire, I have performed it for thirty years, and in all France and Navarre there is not a man in better health than I am. Moreover, I entreat you, sire, not to trouble yourself about me. That would appear very strange to me, seeing that I am not accustomed to it.'

The king cut short the conversation by a fresh question. 'Shall you be here, then, to-morrow morning?'

'As at present? yes, sire.'

The king walked several times up and down his chamber; it was very plain that he burned with a desire to speak, but that he was restrained by some fear or other. The lieutenant, standing motionless, hat in hand, watched him making these evolutions, and, whilst looking at him, grumbled to himself, biting his moustache:

'He has not half a crown worth of resolution! Parole d'honneur! I would lay a wager he does not speak at all!'

The king continued to walk about, casting from time to time a side glance at the lieutenant. 'He is the very image of his father,' continued the latter, in his secret soliloquy, 'he is at once proud, avaricious, and timid. The devil take his master, say I.'

The king stopped. 'Lieutenant,' said he.

'I am here, sire.'

'Why did you cry out this evening, down below in the salons—"The king's service! His majesty's musketeers!"'

'Because you gave me the order, sire.'

'I?' 'Yourself.'

'Indeed, I did not say a word, monsieur.'

'Sire, an order is given by a sign, by a gesture, by a glance, as intelligibly, as freely, and as clearly as by word of mouth. A servant who has nothing but ears is not half a good servant.'

'Your eyes are very penetrating, then, monsieur.'

'How is that, sire?'

'Because they see what is not.'

'What, cardinal!' said the king, 'are you going to consult a lackey about my affairs?'

'Bernouin!' cried the cardinal again, without appearing to remark the humiliation of the young prince. 'Come here, Bernouin, and tell me the figures I gave you just now.'

'Cardinal, cardinal! did you not hear me?' said Louis, turning pale with anger.

'Do not be angry, sire; I deal openly with the affairs of your majesty. Every one in France knows that; my books are as open as day. What did I tell you to do just now, Bernouin?'

'Your eminence commanded me to cast up an account.'

'You did it, did you not?'

'Yes, my lord.'

'To verify the amount of which his majesty, at this moment, stands in need. Did I not tell you so? Be frank, my friend.'

'Your eminence said so.'

'Well, what sum did I say I wanted?'

'Forty-five millions, I think.'

'And what sum could we find, after collecting all our resources?'

'Thirty-nine millions two hundred and sixty thousand.'

'That is correct, Bernouin; that is all I wanted to know. Leave us now,' said the cardinal, fixing his brilliant eye upon the young king, who sat mute with stupefaction.

'However—' stammered the king.

'What, do you still doubt, sire?' said the cardinal. 'Well, here is a proof of what I said.'

And Mazarin drew from under his bolster the paper covered with figures, which he presented to the king, who turned away his eyes, his vexation was so deep.

'Therefore, as it is a million you want, sire, and that million is not set down here, it is forty-six millions your majesty stands in need of. Well, I don't think that any Jews in the world would lend such a sum, even upon the crown of France.'

The king, clenching his hands beneath his ruffles, pushed away his chair.

genius who has saved me, it is for that, I say, that I wish to conciliate the aid of that same genius, and beg you to extend your arm over his head, well assured, monsieur le cardinal, that your hand, by touching him only, would know how to replace upon his brow the crown which fell at the foot of his father's scaffold.'

'Sire,' replied Mazarin, 'I thank you for your good opinion with regard to myself, but we have nothing to do yonder: they are a set of madmen who deny God, and cut off the heads of their kings. They are dangerous, observe, sire, and filthy to the touch after having swallowed in royal blood and covenantal murder. That policy has never suited me,—I scorn it and reject it.'

'Therefore you ought to assist in establishing a better.'

'What is that?'

'The restoration of Charles II, for example.'

'Good heavens!' cried Mazarin, 'does the poor prince flatter himself with that chimera?'

'Yes, he does,' replied the young king, terrified at the difficulties opposed to this project, which he fancied he could perceive in the infallible eye of his minister; 'he only asks for a million to carry out his purpose.'

'Is that all—a little million, if you please!' said the cardinal, ironically, with an effort to conquer his Italian accent. 'A little million, if you please, brother! Bah! a family of mendicants!'

'Cardinal,' said Louis, raising his head, 'that family of mendicants is a branch of my family.'

'Are you rich enough to give millions to other people, sire? Have you millions to throw away?'

'Oh!' replied Louis XIV, with great pain, which he, however, by a strong effort, prevented from appearing on his countenance;—'oh! yes, monsieur le cardinal, I am well aware I am poor, and yet the crown of France is worth a million, and to perform a good action I would pledge my crown if it were necessary. I could find Jews who would be willing to lend me a million.'

'So, sire, you say you want a million?' said Mazarin.

'Yes, monsieur, I say so.'

'You are mistaken, greatly mistaken, sire; you want much more than that,—Bernouin!—you shall see, sire, how much you really want.'

'My eyes are good, though, sire, although they have served their master long and much: when they have anything to see, they seldom miss the opportunity. Now, this evening, they saw that your majesty coloured with endeavouring to conceal the inclination to yawn, that your majesty looked with eloquent supplications, first to his eminence, and then at her majesty, the queen-mother, and at length to the entrance door, and they so thoroughly remarked all I have said, that they saw your majesty's lips articulate these words: "Who will get me out of this?"'

'Monsieur!'

'Or something to this effect, sire—"My musketeers!" I could then no longer hesitate. That look was for me. I cried out instantly, "His majesty's musketeers!" And, besides, that was shown to be true, sire, not only by your majesty's not saying I was wrong, but proving I was right by going out at once.'

The king turned away to smile; then, after a few seconds, he again fixed his limpid eye upon that countenance, so intelligent, so bold, and so firm, that it might have been said to be the proud and energetic profile of the eagle facing the sun. 'That is all very well,' said he, after a short silence, during which he endeavoured, in vain, to make his officer lower his eyes.

But seeing the king said no more, the latter pirouetted on his heels, and took three steps towards the door, muttering, 'He will not speak! Mordoux! he will not speak!'

'Thank you, monsieur,' said the king at last.

'Humph!' continued the lieutenant; 'there was only wanting that. Blamed for having been less of a fool than another might have been.' And he went to the door, allowing his spurs to jingle in true military style. But when he was on the threshold, feeling the king's desire drew him back, he returned.

'Has your majesty told me all?' asked he, in a tone we cannot describe, but which, without appearing to solicit the royal confidence, contained so much persuasive frankness, that the king immediately replied:

'Yes; but draw near, monsieur.'

'Now then,' murmured the officer, 'he is coming to it at last.'

'Listen to me.'

'I shall not lose a word, sire.'

'You will mount on horseback to-morrow, at about half-past four in the morning, and you will have a horse saddled for me.'

'From your majesty's stables?'

'No; one of your musketeers' horses.'

'Very well, sire. Is that all?'

'And you will accompany me.'

'Alone?'

'Alone.'

'Shall I come to seek your majesty, or shall I wait?'

'You will wait for me.'

'Where, sire?'

'At the little park-gate.'

The lieutenant bowed, understanding that the king had told him all he had to say. In fact, the king dismissed him with a gracious wave of the hand. The officer left the chamber of the king, and returned to place himself philosophically in his fauteuil, where, far from sleeping, as might have been expected, considering how late it was, he began to reflect more deeply than he had ever reflected before. The result of these reflections was not so melancholy as the preceding ones had been.

'Come, he has begun,' said he. 'Love urges him on, and he goes forward—he goes forward! The king is nobody in his own palace; but the man perhaps may prove to be worth something. Well, we shall see to-morrow morning. Oh! oh!' cried he, all at once starting up, 'that is a gigantic idea, mordioux! and perhaps my fortune depends, at least, upon that idea!' After this exclamation, the officer arose and marched, with his hands in the pockets of his justaucorps, about the immense ante-chamber that served him as an apartment. The wax-light flamed furiously under the effects of a fresh breeze, which stole in through the chinks of the door and the window, and cut the *salle diagonally*. It threw out a reddish, unequal light, sometimes brilliant, sometimes dull, and the tall shadow of the lieutenant was seen marching on the wall, in profile, like a figure by Calot, with his long sword and feathered hat.

'Certainly!' said he, 'I am mistaken if Mazarin is not laying a snare for this amorous boy. Mazarin, this evening, gave an address, and made an appointment as complacently as M. Daangeau himself could have done—I heard him, and I know the meaning of his words. "To-morrow morning," said he, "they will pass opposite the bridge of Blois." Mordioux! that is clear enough, and particularly for a lover. That is the cause of this embarrassment; that is the

not caused by the bashfulness of a juvenile passion, but only by the painful contraction of the royal pride.

Like a good uncle, Mazarin felt disposed to facilitate the confidence.

'Speak, sire,' said he, 'and since your majesty is willing for an instant to forget that I am your subject, and call me your master and instructor, I promise your majesty my most devoted and tender consideration.'

'Thanks, monsieur le cardinal,' answered the king; 'that which I have to ask of your eminence has but little to do with myself.'

'So much the worse!' replied the cardinal; 'so much the worse! Sire, I should wish your majesty to ask of me something of importance, even a sacrifice; but whatever it may be that you ask me, I am ready to set your heart at rest by granting it, my dear sire.'

'Well, this is what brings me here,' said the king, with a beating of the heart that had no equal except the beating of the heart of the minister; 'I have just received a visit from my brother, the king of England.'

Mazarin bounded in his bed as if he had been put in relation with a Leyden jar or a voltaic pile, at the same time that a surprise, or rather a manifest disappointment, inflamed his features with such a blaze of anger, that Louis XIV, little diplomatist as he was, saw that the minister had hoped to hear something else.

'Charles II.?' exclaimed Mazarin, with a hoarse voice and a disdainful movement of his lips. 'You have received a visit from Charles II.?'

'From King Charles II.,' replied Louis, according in a marked manner to the grandson of Henry IV the title which Mazarin had forgotten to give him. 'Yes, monsieur le cardinal, that unhappy prince has touched my heart with the relation of his misfortunes. His distress is great, monsieur le cardinal, and it has appeared painful to me, who have seen my own throne disputed, who have been forced in times of commotion to quit my capital,—to me, in short, who am acquainted with misfortune,—to leave a deposed and fugitive brother without assistance.'

'Eh!' said the cardinal, sharply; 'why had he not, as you have, a Jules Mazarin by his side? His crown would then have remained intact.'

'I know all that my house owes to your eminence,' replied the king, haughtily, 'and you may well believe that I, on my part, shall never forget it. It is precisely because my brother, the king of England has not about him the powerful

‘Oh!’ said Mazarin, when the valet had gone out; ‘not yet forty millions! I must, however, attain that sum, which I had set down for myself. But who knows whether I shall have time? I sink, I am going, I shall never reach it! And yet, who knows that I may not find two or three millions in the pockets of my good friends the Spaniards? They discovered Peru, those people did, and—what the devil! they must have something left.’

As he was speaking thus, entirely occupied with his ciphers, and thinking no more of his gout, repelled by a preoccupation which, with the cardinal, was the most powerful of all preoccupations, Bernouin rushed into the chamber, quite in a fright.

‘Well!’ asked the cardinal, ‘what is the matter now?’

‘The king, monseigneur,—the king!’

‘How?—the king!’ said Mazarin, quickly concealing his paper. ‘The king here! the king at this hour! I thought he was in bed long ago. What is the matter, then?’

The king could hear these last words, and see the terrified gesture of the cardinal rising up in his bed, for he entered the chamber at that moment.

‘It is nothing, monsieur le cardinal, or at least nothing which can alarm you. It is an important communication which I wish to make to your eminence to-night,—that is all.’

Mazarin immediately thought of that marked attention which the king had given to his words concerning Mademoiselle de Mancini, and the communication appeared to him probably to refer to this source. He recovered his serenity then instantly, and assumed his most agreeable air, a change of countenance which inspired the king with the greatest joy; and when Louis was seated,—

‘Sire,’ said the cardinal, ‘I ought certainly to listen to your majesty standing, but the violence of my complaint—’

‘No ceremony between us, my dear monsieur le cardinal,’ said Louis kindly; ‘I am your pupil, and not the king, you know very well, and this evening in particular, as I come to you as a petitioner, as a solicitor, and one very humble, and desirous to be kindly received, too.’

Mazarin, seeing the heightened colour of the king, was confirmed in his first idea; that is to say, that love thoughts were hidden under all these fine words. This time, political cunning, as keen as it was, made a mistake; this colour was

cause of this hesitation; that is the cause of this order—“Monsieur the lieutenant of my musketeers, be on horseback to-morrow at four o’clock in the morning.” Which is as clear as if he had said,—“Monsieur the lieutenant of my musketeers, to-morrow, at four, at the bridge of Blois,—do you understand?” Here is a stare secret, then, which I, humble as I am, have in my possession, while it is in action. And how do I get it? Because I have good eyes, as his majesty just now said. They say he loves this little Italian doll furiously. They say he threw himself at his mother’s feet, to beg her to allow him to marry her. They say the queen went so far as to consult the court of Rome, whether such a marriage, contracted against her will, would be valid. Oh, if I were but twenty-five! If I had by my side those I no longer have! If I did not despise the whole world most profoundly, I would embroil Mazarin with the queen-mother, France with Spain, and I would make a queen after my own fashion. But let that pass.’ And the lieutenant snapped his fingers in disdain.

‘This miserable Italian—this poor creature—this sordid wretch—who has just refused the king of England a million, would not perhaps give me a thousand pistoles for the news I would carry him. Mordoux! I am falling into second childhood—I am becoming stupid indeed! The idea of Mazarin giving anything! ha! ha! ha!’ and he laughed in a subdued voice.

‘Well, let us go to sleep—let us go to sleep, and the sooner the better. My mind is wearied with my evening’s work, and will see things to-morrow more clearly than to-day.’

And upon this recommendation, made to himself, he folded his cloak around him, looking with contempt upon his royal neighbour. Five minutes after this he was asleep, with his hands clenched and his lips apart, giving escape, not to his secret, but to a sonorous sound, which rose and spread freely beneath the majestic roof of the ante-chamber.

‘Eh! monseigneur; whether it be spent or put away is of very little consequence to me, since none of these millions are mine.’

‘These millions are the king’s; it is the king’s money I am reckoning. Well, what were we saying? You always interrupt me!’

‘Seven millions upon Bordeaux.’

‘Ah! yes; that’s right. Upon Madrid four millions. I give you to understand plainly to whom this money belongs, Bernouin, seeing that everybody has the stupidity to believe me rich in millions. I repel the silly idea. A minister, besides, has nothing of his own. Come, go on. Rentrées generales, seven millions; properties, nine millions. Have you written that, Bernouin?’

‘Yes, monseigneur.’

‘Bourse, six hundred thousand livres; various property, two millions. Ah! I forgot—the furniture of the different châteaux—’

‘Must I put of the crown?’ asked Bernouin.

‘No, no; it is of no use doing that—that is understood. Have you written that, Bernouin?’

‘Yes, monseigneur.’

‘And the ciphers?’

‘Stand straight under one another.’

‘Cast them up, Bernouin.’

‘Thirty-nine millions two hundred and sixty thousand livres, monseigneur.’

‘Ah!’ cried the cardinal, in a tone of vexation; ‘there are not yet forty millions!’

Bernouin recommenced the addition.

‘No, monseigneur; there want seven hundred and forty thousand livres.’

Mazarin asked for the account, and revised it carefully.

‘Yes, but,’ said Bernouin, ‘thirty-nine millions two hundred and sixty thousand livres make a good round sum.’

‘Ah, Bernouin; I wish the king had it.’

‘Your eminence told me that this money was his majesty’s.’

‘Doubtless, as clear, as transparent as possible. These thirty-nine millions are bespoken, and much more.’

Bernouin smiled after his own fashion—that is, like a man who believes no more than he is willing to believe—whilst preparing the cardinal’s night draught, and putting his pillow to rights.